

CURRENT AFFAIRS



WEST ASIA ... THREE AXES



28th WEEK 2017

UPSC

CAPSULE - 1

ALL EXAMS

10th July to 16th July, 2017

INDIA



IRAN



ISRAEL



SAUDI ARABIA



WHY WEST ASIA IS SO IMPORTANT?

1 INDIAN DIASPORA

- Almost seven to eight million-strong Indian diaspora is in West Asia, who contribute remittances of around \$40 billion annually.
- Their security is a politically sensitive issue for the Indian Government.



2 ENERGY SECURITY

- About 60% of all Indian oil imports (it is even more, if we consider the natural gas) comes from West Asia. Hence India is highly dependent on this region for its energy needs.



3 COUNTER TERRORISM

- Israel is quite strong in counterterrorism operations and India's Research and Analysis Wing and Israel's Mossad established relations long back.
- Israel is very important, when one looks at security and intelligence sharing mechanisms, as well as broader defence partnerships across the region.





WEST ASIA ... CHANGED CIRCUMSTANCES

- 1** US may play a less active role as a security guarantor in the region, which is evident from Donald Trump's statements.
- 2** The Arab Spring, which started in 2010/11 resulted in civil wars in Syria, Iraq, Libya, Yemen and also resulted in the breakdown of governance in Egypt.
- 3** The 2015 Iran nuclear agreement might have emboldened Tehran and it generated fears in other Sunni majority countries.
- 4** Oil prices remained low and several Gulf Arab countries are beginning to plan for a post-oil future. The Saudi Vision 2030, is the signature project in this direction.
- 5** In this complex scenario, in recent times, ties between Saudi Arabia and its allies and Qatar turned from bad to worse.



SAUDI ARABIA

- Officially “Kingdom of Saudi Arabia”
 - Arab State in West Asia
 - 2nd Largest proven oil reserves in the world
 - Occupies major portion of Arabian Peninsula
 - Got coastline across both the Red Sea and the Persian Gulf
 - Population ... Around 3 crore (approx.)
 - Capital ... Riyadh
 - Currency ... Saudi Riyal
- Kingdom of Saudi Arabia was founded in 1932 by Ibn Saud
 - Islamic absolute monarchy
 - It promotes conservative Wahhabism
 - Predominantly Sunni Islam
 - Leads 6 Nation GCC countries
 - Founder of 39 Nation block of Islamic Military Alliance to Fight Terrorism (IMAFT)
 - Global leader for “Sunni Muslim” sect





IRAN

- Officially “Islamic Republic of Iran” also known as Persia
- Extends from Caspian Sea to Persian Gulf and Gulf of Oman
- One of the world’s largest proven oil reserves and natural gas reserves
- Islamic Republic, with the concept of “Supreme Leader”
- Population ... 8 crores (approx.)
- Capital .. Tehran
- Currency ... Rial
- Known for “Islamic Revolution” of 1979
- Global leader for “Shia Muslim Sect”
- Antagonized USA & West for the past “35 years”
- Sanctions were lifted only in 2015 after the “historic nuclear deal” with world powers (P5+1)
- Official language ... Persian
- It supports Shia Militias in several countries





SAUDI ARABIA - IRAN



SAUDI ARABIA

- 1 It is the global leader for Sunni sect of Muslims
- 2 It leads the group of Sunni dominated GCC countries
- 3 Close relations with USA and West for the past several decades
- 4 It is supporting Govt. forces in Yemen civil war
- 5 It is supporting opposition forces in Syria civil war

IRAN

- 1 It is the global leader for Shia sect of Muslims
- 2 It backs Shia Militias to fight on behalf of the Shia Muslim countries
- 3 It antagonised USA and West after 1979 revolution and it used to call America "the biggest enemy"
- 4 It is allegedly supporting Houthi rebels in Yemen
- 5 It is supporting Govt. forces in Syria civil war



INDIA - SAUDI ARABIA



- 1 Out of 7 million Indians staying in West Asia region, Saudi Arabia accounts for around 3 million and hence several families in India are dependent on remittances
- 2 Bilateral trade is around \$ 40 bn and is one of the key countries for India's energy security
- 3 The country has got one of the largest SWFs and India can leverage these funds for infrastructure development in India
- 4 In recent times, both the countries stepped up cooperation in counter terrorism and intelligence sharing
- 5 Alleged exploitation of the Indian labourers is the point of concern for India. Not only that, India is also worried about the alleged funding of Wahhabi groups



INDIA - IRAN



1

Even during the times of economic sanctions by the West, India maintained reasonably good relations with Iran. Iran is one of the largest importers of Basmati rice from India for the past few years

2

India is going to develop Chabahar port, which will be gateway to Central Asia as well as Afghanistan. This assumed significance in view of the development of Gwadar port by China in Pakistan

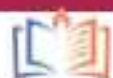
3

India also wants Indian firms to develop Farzad-B gas fields in Iran

4

Iran has got second highest natural gas reserves in the world and it will add to India's energy security. Discussions are also going on for Iran-Pakistan-India gas pipeline





SAGA OF INDIA - ISRAEL RELATIONS



- 1 India established diplomatic relations in 1992.
- 2 NSA level dialogue started in 1999, which resulted in cementing the ties between MOSSAD and the Research & Analysis Wing.
- 3 Gradually, the defence and the counter-terrorism cooperation relationship increased and at present, India is Israel's largest defence client.
- 4 By 2000, India was acquiring surface-to-air missiles (Barak 1) and Unmanned Aerial Vehicles from Israel.
- 5 MiG-21 aircrafts were refurbished by Israeli avionics.
- 6 During the 1999 Kargil war, Israel assisted with laser-guidance kits mated with gravity bombs, carried by the Mirage 2000 aircraft.
- 7 With U.S. concurrence, Israel sold India the Phalcon airborne early warning system and mounted on the Russian Il-76, provided AWACs capability.
- 8 Subsequent acquisitions included Spike anti-tank guided missiles and the long range surface-to-air missiles in both the naval and land versions.

Today, Israel has emerged as the third-largest defence supplier for India and accounts for over 40% of Israel's defence exports.



MOSSAD



THE RESEARCH & ANALYSIS WING



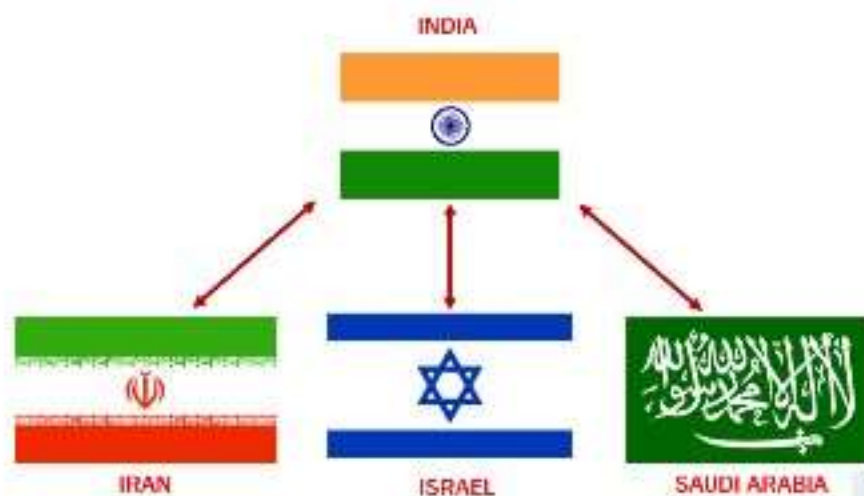
INDIA - ISRAEL ... OTHER ASPECTS

- 1 Commercial relations between the diamond traders in Gujarat and Israel had existed before 1992.
- 2 The annual trade grew from \$200 million to nearly \$5 billion, with gems and jewellery accounting for nearly 40%.
- 3 Tourism provided an impetus to people-to-people relations and India emerged as the preferred destination for young Israelis wanting to unwind after their compulsory military service.
- 4 Science and technology, agriculture, biotech and space emerged as new areas of cooperation.





INDIA ... CAREFUL STRATEGY FOR THE VISIT



- 1 The Indian Prime Minister had already undertaken visits to the United Arab Emirates, Saudi Arabia, Qatar and Iran before undertaking his trip to Israel.
- 2 India has already hosted Palestinian President Mahmoud Abbas in Delhi.
- 3 Several preparatory visits between India and Israel took place covering diverse areas of agriculture, water resources and space.
- 4 On the Israeli side, the Cabinet approved a 23-page document identifying potential cooperation areas with India.



IMPORTANT DEVELOPMENTS IN VIEW OF FIRST-EVER VISIT OF INDIAN PRIME MINISTER



- 1 The bilateral relationship is raised to a strategic partnership.
- 2 Seven agreements were signed and one of them includes \$40 million joint fund for research and development in innovation.
- 3 Strong measures should be taken against terrorists, terror organisations, their networks and all those who encourage, support and finance terrorism, or provide sanctuary to terrorists and terror groups.
- 4 Terrorist organisations do not get access to any WMD [Weapons of Mass Destruction] or technologies.
- 5 The Joint Statement recorded supports for an early negotiated solution between the sides (Israel and Palestine) based on mutual recognition and security arrangements.

This is without any reference to a two-state solution that India supports.

FURTHER ASPECTS ABOUT 7 AGREEMENTS

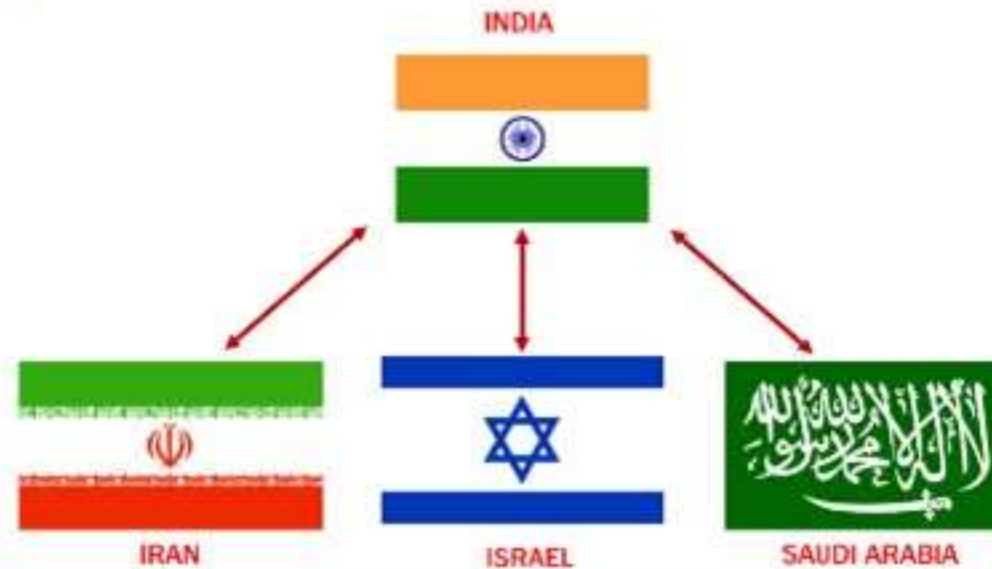
- 1** An agreement in the field of water deals with the increasing awareness of the need for water conservation, between the Israeli Water Ministry and the Uttar Pradesh Jal Nigam Board.
- 2** Three MoUs on space cooperation included one for Electric Propulsion for Small Satellites, and for the development of an optical link as well as cooperation on atomic clocks.
- 3** The fund of research and development, called the India Israel Industrial Innovation Fund (I4F), will see both governments contribute \$20 million each to help research scholars manufacture their inventions easily.



Uttar Pradesh Jal Nigam



FOR INDIAWHAT NEXT?

**1**

Multi-directional West Asia Policy

2

Maintain equilibrium with caution

3

Do not take sides in the murky geopolitics of West Asia

4

Concentrate on economic & trade relations

5

Delink terror from religion



The visit of Narendra Modi to Israel resulted in coming out of the hesitations of history and at the same time, the need of the hour is to maintain delicate balance in the highly sensitive West Asia between Iran, Saudi Arabia and Israel.

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